

By **M.G. Radhakrishnan**

With several stories of crime and sleaze being spun around the Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB), which alone administers Kerala's 1,210 temples, the state Government finally seems to have swung into action. Among the many stories is one on the involvement of the head priest of the Sabarimala Sree Ayyappa Temple in a brawl inside a city apartment that belonged to a woman accused in numerous cases of crimes in 2006. Later, a report by a retired high court Judge added to the general grief by pointing out that most priests who were appointed in the temples were ignorant of even the basic theological knowledge required for the post. It was in the wake of such incidents that the Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government decided to fundamentally restructure the two main state boards, the TDB and the Cochin Devaswom Board (CDB), and finally put an end to the notoriety the state's priests were gaining.

In 2007, a Bill was formulated to amend the existing Travancore Kochi Religious Institutions Act of 1950 which had created the two autonomous boards. The TDB and the CDB together administer 1,700



Temple MUDDLE

A Bill that seeks to cleanse and streamline the boards that run the state's temples runs into an opposition dug in against what it calls an atheistic attempt at control

temples in the central and southern parts of the state, including the richest shrine of Sabarimala which alone brings in Rs 150 crore and attracts 30 million pilgrims every year.

"The Bill is the first major attempt after 1950 to cleanse the TDB of rampant corruption and to protect the interests of true devotees. Not a single TDB appointed by either the UDF or the LDF has been free of corruption," says

G. Sudhakaran, the state cooperation minister, the architect of the Bill when he had held temple affairs portfolio. He points out that it is a "revolutionary bill" as for the first time members from the Scheduled Castes (SC) and women have been given reserved slots in the management of the boards. "Even social reformers and devotional singers too have been given reserved slots in the boards,"

says Kadannappally Ramachandran, minister for temple administration.

However, after the recent tabling of the Amendment Bill in the state Assembly, the United Democratic Front (UDF) and various Hindu groups have risen up in arms against what they see as a naked attempt by the "atheist" Government to control temples and destroy the autonomy of the TDB. For the first time, certain